The Quiet Exclusion of Independent Researchers

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Abstract

Scientific exclusion is typically understood as the result of explicit rejection. However, participation can also be constrained without any formal decision. This paper introduces the concept of *quiet exclusion* to describe situations in which access is restricted through entry barriers, delays, non-response, or non-progressive evaluation processes. Drawing on documented cases across platforms and journal workflows, including Zenodo, ResearchGate, arXiv, and journal submission systems, the analysis shows that exclusion can occur at multiple stages, from registration to evaluation. These mechanisms differ in form but converge in outcome: they prevent effective participation without producing an identifiable rejection event. The paper proposes a process-based model of access, defined by entry, progression, and completion. Within this framework, exclusion arises whenever any of these components fails, even in the absence of explicit denial. This perspective reframes openness not as a binary condition, but as a process whose structure can silently restrict participation.

Introduction

Scientific exclusion is typically framed as explicit rejection. However, in many cases, no rejection ever occurs. Systems appear open and accessible, yet participation is effectively constrained through processes that produce no formal denial. This paper defines these mechanisms as quiet exclusion. Quiet exclusion describes situations in which independent researchers are unable to enter or progress within scientific platforms, not through formal rejection, but through opaque validation procedures, prolonged non-response, or implicit requirements such as institutional email verification.

Unlike explicit gatekeeping, this mechanism generates no clear decision, no appeal pathway, and minimal visibility, making it difficult to detect, contest, or quantify. Prior work on peer review opacity and editorial discretion has shown that decision processes in science are not always transparent and may involve informal or implicit criteria (Smith, 2006; Tennant et al., 2017).

The present study develops this framework through documented cases involving Zenodo, ResearchGate, arXiv, and the journal *Human Factors*. Across these cases, exclusion does not emerge as a single decision but as a distributed process unfolding across registration systems, platform validation procedures, editorial workflows, and legitimacy heuristics. Rather than being explicitly enacted, it results from the cumulative effect of small frictions at each stage, producing an indeterminate yet effective restriction of scientific participation, particularly for independent researchers. This aligns with broader findings that cumulative disadvantage and structural barriers can emerge from seemingly minor procedural constraints (Merton, 1968; Edwards & Roy, 2017).

Beyond structural factors, the analysis highlights the role of ordinary operational dynamics in maintaining such exclusion. Limited support responsiveness, reliance on implicit norms of legitimacy, and the absence of accountability in user validation workflows sustain barriers without requiring explicit intent. The interaction between automated systems and human non-response stabilizes a form of exclusion that is decentralized, persistent, and difficult to attribute to any single actor, echoing observations about algorithmic governance and distributed responsibility in digital systems (Pasquale, 2015; Gillespie, 2014).

The implications extend beyond individual cases. Structural and human-mediated exclusion at the level of platform access may introduce systematic biases in knowledge production by selectively limiting the visibility and contribution of non-institutional work. These biases do not emerge through explicit rejection, but through low-visibility mechanisms embedded in access, validation, and support processes. Concerns about inequities in open science infrastructures and participation have been raised in prior literature (Mirowski, 2018; Fecher & Friesike, 2014).

This challenges the assumption that open systems are inherently accessible. In practice, participation may be constrained through opacity, weak accountability, and non-response, without any formal exclusion. The concept of quiet exclusion shifts attention from visible decisions to the processes that silently govern access.

Methodological Note

This paper adopts a case-based analytical approach to examine access processes in open science platforms. The analysis draws on three complementary types of material:

- Documented first-person interactions: direct records of submission attempts, platform responses, and account actions, including rejection messages, automated classifications, support requests, and instances of non-response.
- Platform-level observable structures: publicly accessible rules, submission conditions, and interface-level constraints shaping entry, evaluation, and dissemination.
- Process-level interpretation: analytical reconstruction of access as a sequence of stages (entry, progression, completion), used to identify where and how participation may be interrupted.

The objective is not to evaluate the validity of individual decisions, but to characterize recurring process patterns that can produce exclusion without explicit rejection.

The case studies are not intended to be exhaustive or statistically representative. Rather, they serve as analytical probes to identify recurrent mechanisms across heterogeneous contexts.

Where available, supporting materials (e.g., screenshots, structured records) are included to document specific interactions. These are used illustratively and do not imply general prevalence.

By focusing on process rather than isolated decisions, this approach enables the identification of low-visibility barriers that emerge from the structure and dynamics of access systems.

Case Study 1. Human Factors Submission (Response Loop Without Progression)

Context

An independent researcher submitted a manuscript to *Human Factors*. Following initial submission, the journal returned the manuscript with a specific and actionable request: to reformat the references according to APA guidelines (including alphabetical order and hanging indentation). This response indicates that the submission passed an initial screening stage and was considered eligible for further processing, conditional on minor formatting corrections.

Sequence of Events

- **Initial submission**

  Manuscript submitted through the journal's standard system.

- **Editorial request**

  The journal requested specific formatting corrections (APA references).

- **Resubmission**

  The author implemented the requested changes and resubmitted the manuscript.

- **Post-correction phase**

  Following resubmission, the author received repeated requests corresponding to previously addressed formatting issues, without observable progression toward evaluation.

Observed Mechanism

The interaction entered a **response loop**, defined by continued communication without state transition. Each response from the author satisfied the stated requirements, yet the system returned to the same request state, preventing advancement to peer review or editorial decision. The process did not simply involve a request for correction. The same justification was repeatedly returned, with responses arriving after a highly regular delay, approximately eight hours each time. This created the appearance of editorial movement while effectively prolonging the process and increasing waiting time without substantive progression.

Observed Outcome

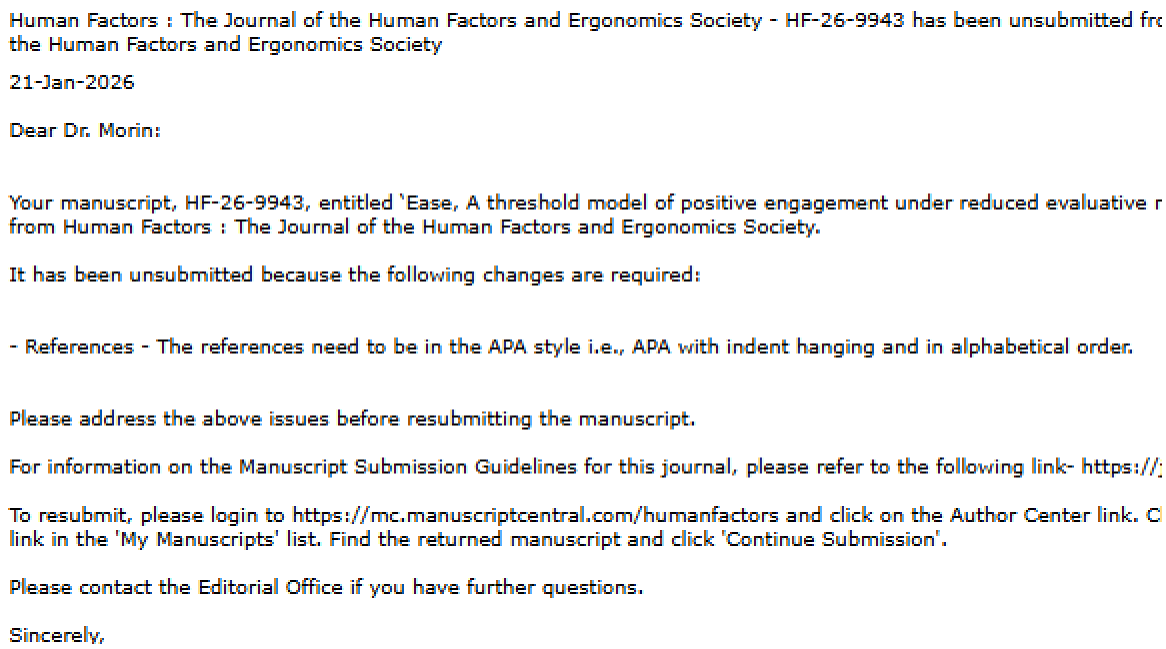
- No acceptance

- No rejection

- No additional substantive feedback

- No confirmation of processing status

The manuscript remained in an indeterminate state despite compliance with editorial requirements, see figure 1 and 2.


Human Factors : The Journal of the Human Factors and Ergonomics Society - HF-26-9943 has been unsubmitted frc
the Human Factors and Ergonomics Society

21-Jan-2026

Dear Dr. Morin:

Your manuscript, HF-26-9943, entitled 'Ease, A threshold model of positive engagement under reduced evaluative r
from Human Factors : The Journal of the Human Factors and Ergonomics Society.

It has been unsubmitted because the following changes are required:

- References - The references need to be in the APA style i.e., APA with indent hanging and in alphabetical order.

Please address the above issues before resubmitting the manuscript.

For information on the Manuscript Submission Guidelines for this journal, please refer to the following link- https://

To resubmit, please login to https://mc.manuscriptcentral.com/humanfactors and click on the Author Center link. C
link in the 'My Manuscripts' list. Find the returned manuscript and click 'Continue Submission'.

Please contact the Editorial Office if you have further questions.

Sincerely,

Figure 1: Manuscript repeatedly returned for identical APA formatting request, with automated 8-hour response cycles and no progression.

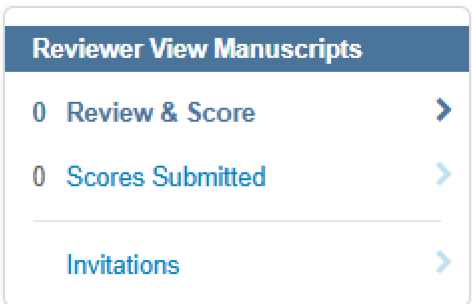


Figure 2: No reviewers assigned and no scores submitted, indicating no progression to peer review.

In one of the platform menus, the category "independent researcher" is still explicitly displayed, including three months after the observed access restrictions (see Figure 3), suggesting a persistent discrepancy between interface-level openness and effective access conditions.

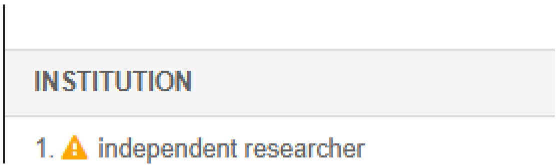


Figure 3: Affiliation field displaying "independent researcher" marked with a warning icon in the submission interface.

Interpretation

This case illustrates a transition from a transparent interaction phase to a non-responsive state within the same submission process. The initial request indicates active editorial engagement, characterized by clear and actionable criteria for revision. This suggests that the manuscript had entered a valid processing pathway rather than being filtered out at entry.

However, the absence of substantive follow-up after resubmission signals a breakdown in process continuity. The interaction persists, but without progression toward evaluation. This creates an interrupted evaluation pathway, in which the submission is neither advanced, rejected, nor formally closed.

This case illustrates a progression failure within the access process, where compliance does not produce state transition, resulting in effective exclusion without explicit rejection.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

Unlike immediate rejection, this pattern does not produce a visible exclusion outcome. Instead, it generates a condition characterized by uncertainty regarding manuscript status, absence of evaluative feedback, and lack of actionable next steps.

This configuration aligns with the concept of quiet exclusion and extends it to post-engagement scenarios. In this case, the system permits entry and initiates interaction, but fails to sustain progression toward evaluation. The exclusion mechanism therefore operates within the progression phase rather than at entry.

Rather than blocking access outright, the process remains formally open while functionally inactive. This prevents completion of the evaluation loop without producing a definitive outcome.

Key Insight

Exclusion may occur not only at the point of entry, but also after partial compliance with system requirements, through sustained non-response. In such cases, exclusion is enacted through the interruption of progression rather than through explicit rejection.

Case Study 2. Registration Barrier and Conditional Verification on ResearchGate

Context

An independent researcher attempted to create an account on ResearchGate, a platform presented as open to researchers, including those without institutional affiliation. During registration, multiple entry categories are offered at the same level, including "Academic or Student" and "Independent Researcher," suggesting equivalent access pathways.

Sequence of Events

Initial registration

The user selects the "Independent Researcher" option during account creation.

Institutional information request

The platform requests institutional affiliation. An option to "skip this step" is available, implying that institutional information is not strictly required for entry.

Email verification step

After skipping institutional affiliation, the user is prompted to provide an email address. A message appears: "You haven't provided your institutional email. Signing up with a personal email requires extra steps for us to verify that you're a researcher – your institutional email gives you instant access.”

Authorship verification attempt

The platform then presents a verification interface: “Please confirm your authorship – is this you? Tell us which of these publications are yours to add your research to your profile.”

Verification failure

If the user does not have publications already indexed within the platform, the system returns the following message: “Sorry, we couldn't verify that you are a researcher from the information you provided. We therefore require you to enter your institutional email address to verify that you are a scientific professional.” Supporting materials are provided in Appendix 1.

Interpretation

This sequence reveals a conditional access structure. While the interface presents “Independent Researcher” as a valid entry category, effective access remains dependent on institutional signals, either through email domain or pre-indexed publications.

The very name “ResearchGate” encapsulates this logic: access to research is not simply provided, but mediated through a gate, structured by implicit validation and visibility thresholds.

The “skip” option functions as a nominal pathway rather than an operational one. In practice, verification requirements reintroduce institutional dependency at a later stage, creating a deferred entry barrier.

As a result, the system allows initial registration steps but blocks completion for users lacking recognized institutional markers, producing exclusion *without explicit rejection* at the point of entry.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This pattern differs from both explicit rejection and pure non-response. Instead, it constitutes a form of **conditional exclusion through recursive validation**.

The system:

- allows initial entry
- provides the appearance of optional institutional requirements
- progressively restricts access through validation dependencies

The outcome is a blocked state without formal refusal, where access is technically possible but practically unattainable for certain user profiles.

This aligns with the concept of quiet exclusion by producing:

- functional denial of access
- absence of appeal or alternative pathway
- reliance on implicit legitimacy signal

Key Insight

Exclusion can be embedded within multi-step validation processes that appear flexible at the interface level but converge toward strict institutional requirements. The presence of an "independent researcher" category does not guarantee effective accessibility if downstream verification mechanisms depend on institutional or pre-indexed signals.

Case Study 3. Automated Restriction and Non-Response Following Active Use on Zenodo

Context

An independent researcher actively used Zenodo to upload and manage research outputs, including multiple document versions over a period of approximately six weeks. The activity followed standard platform functionality, including versioning and iterative updates. Further details can be found in Appendix 2.

Sequence of Events

Initial uploads

The researcher uploaded research documents and engaged in standard platform use, including versioning and updates.

Sustained activity phase

Over several weeks, multiple uploads and revisions were performed using built-in features, without indication of policy violation or restriction.

Automated restriction

Following this period of activity, the account was automatically restricted or flagged for spam-related reasons. No prior warning or specific explanation was provided regarding the triggering condition, as shown in Figure 4.

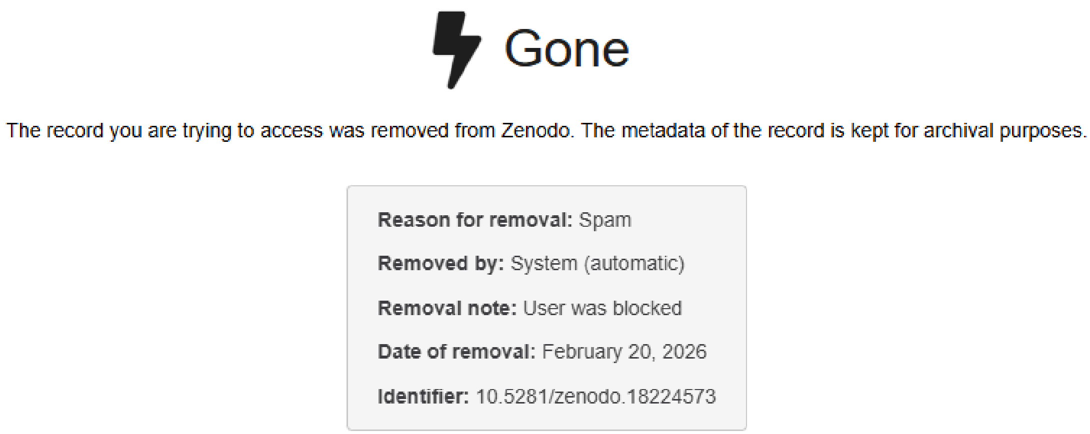


Figure Screenshot showing automated removal of a record labeled as "spam," accompanied by account blocking. The decision is presented without detailed justification or actionable feedback, and the record becomes inaccessible. This illustrates a form of exclusion combining automated classification, lack of procedural transparency, and absence of clear recovery pathway. Automated classification systems can produce immediate and non-negotiable exclusion outcomes, often with limited transparency and no clear mechanism for contestation.

Post-restriction phase

The researcher contacted platform support to request clarification and restoration of access. Despite explicit system feedback indicating that a confirmation message would be sent, no confirmation was received, resulting in uncertainty regarding submission status.

Non-response period

No response was received over a period exceeding four weeks, leaving the account in a restricted state without resolution.

This contrast is already visible in platform-level communication (see Figure 4), where openness and accessibility are prominently emphasized.

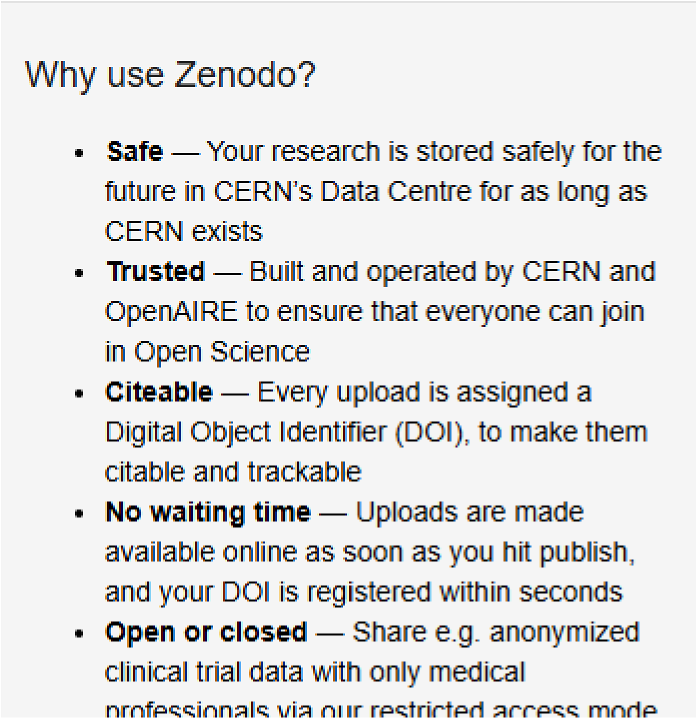


Figure 4. The platform homepage emphasizes safety, trust, openness, and immediate availability. Yet these assurances may be unevenly realized in practice, particularly for independent researchers who lack institutional markers that reduce the risk of automated filtering or administrative friction.

By stating that institutional email addresses reduce the likelihood of spam classification, the platform implicitly normalizes a filtering mechanism that disproportionately affects independent researchers, while framing it as a neutral security feature, see figure 5.

Zenodo FAQ > Content > What can I do to avoid spam detection?

What can I do to avoid spam detection?

Everything you post or submit on Zenodo is subject to automated and/or manual review by our automated spam classification system. The system is dealing with large volumes of submissions on a daily basis, and while we strive to make it as accurate as possible, the system may occasionally make mistakes. The following is some of the actions you can take to ensure the spam classification system has enough information to determine your upload is ham.

1. Register with an institutional email address (avoid generic mail providers)

We encourage you to register with an institutional email address (e.g. provided by a university). If you already registered with another email address you can change your email address. We have very little spam from users having an institutional email address, and thus an institutional email address is a strong indicator that a submission is not spam. On the other hand, we have significant amount of spam coming from users using generic mail providers like gmail, outlook, yahoo and others. For help on how to create an account or change email address see:

- https://help.zenodo.org/docs/get-started/create-an-account/
- https://help.zenodo.org/docs/profile/editing-your-profile/#edit

Figure 5. Independent researchers, who typically rely on generic email providers, may therefore be more exposed to automated spam classification or related submission barriers.

Interpretation

This case illustrates exclusion occurring after successful entry and sustained participation. Unlike entry barriers, the restriction emerges during the progression phase, interrupting an already active workflow.

The automated classification introduces a non-transparent decision point, where the criteria for restriction are neither visible nor contestable. The subsequent absence of response prevents recovery or clarification, effectively stabilizing the restricted state.

As a result, access is not denied at entry but revoked during use, and then maintained through non-response. The process remains open in principle, but functionally closed in practice.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This case extends the concept of quiet exclusion to post-access scenarios involving automated systems. The exclusion process unfolds across multiple stages: successful entry and sustained use of the platform, followed by sudden restriction without explicit criteria, absence of feedback or corrective pathway, and prolonged non-response after appeal attempts.

In contrast to explicit bans, which typically provide justification and closure, this configuration produces a form of functional exclusion without transparent decision-making. The system signals restriction but does not expose the conditions required for reversal.

Within a process-based framework, exclusion occurs after both entry and progression have been achieved. The disruption takes place at the level of continuation and recovery, where access is revoked and cannot be restored due to the absence of responsive mechanisms.

Key Insight

Exclusion can occur after successful integration into a platform through the interaction of automated moderation and absent support response. In such cases, compliant activity may be reclassified as problematic without explanation, while the absence of follow-up prevents clarification or recovery, effectively stabilizing the exclusion state (figure 6).

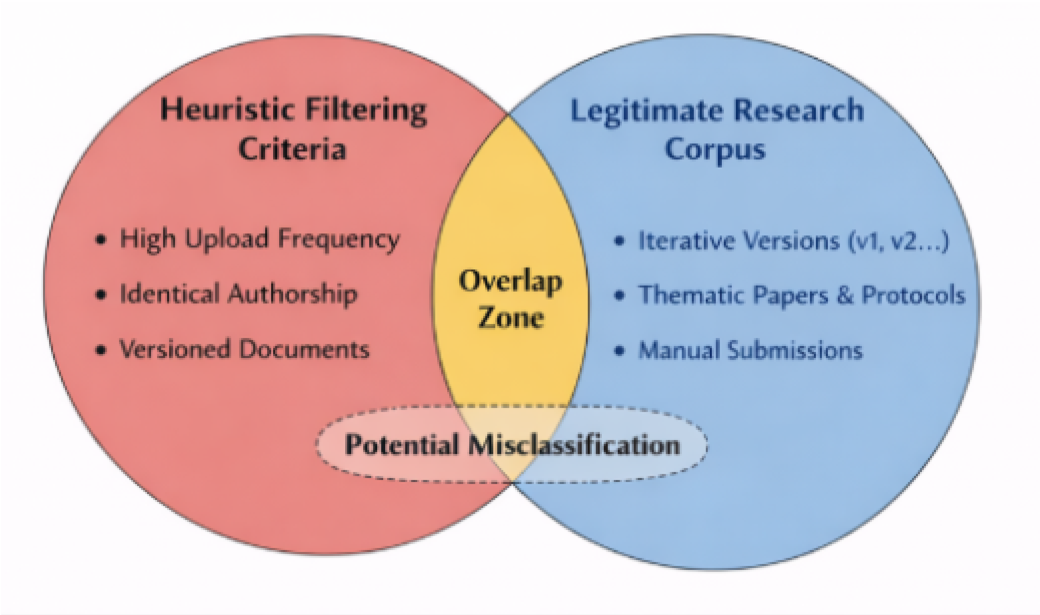


Figure 6. Overlap exists between automated heuristic filtering and legitimate research workflows. Practices such as high upload frequency, consistent authorship, and iterative versioning can generate patterns similar to those targeted by spam detection systems, while remaining standard in structured research dissemination. This creates a boundary region in which behavioral signals are ambiguous. Within this region, automated systems may produce false positives, leading to misclassification without clear justification. This case illustrates how legitimate research practices can become indistinguishable from filtered behaviors under

automated moderation, enabling exclusion without explicit intent or transparent decision-making.

Variants of Access Filtering in Other Preprint Platforms

Preprint platforms are often described as open infrastructures enabling rapid and broad dissemination of scientific work. However, access conditions vary across platforms and reveal distinct forms of entry regulation that can differentially affect independent researchers.

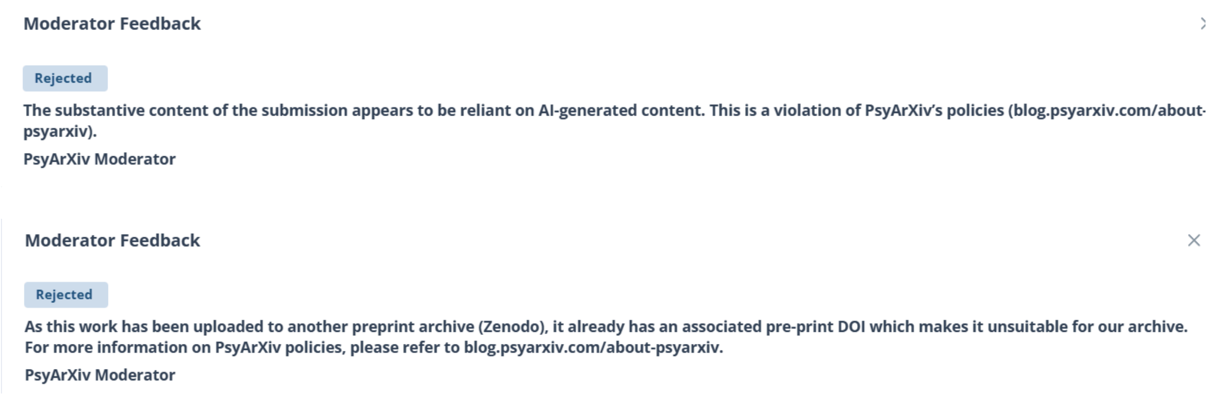
On arXiv, access to submission is mediated through an endorsement system in certain subject areas. New authors must be endorsed by an established contributor before they are allowed to submit. This mechanism is explicit and formally documented, making the entry barrier visible. However, it introduces a dependency on existing network connections, which may disadvantage researchers without prior integration into academic networks.

Platforms such as PsyArXiv and other Open Science Framework-based repositories operate under a more permissive model, allowing submissions without formal endorsement requirements. Despite this openness at entry, moderation and screening processes may still be applied, introducing less visible forms of regulation during or after submission, see figure 7.

bioRxiv represents an intermediate configuration. While institutional affiliation is not strictly required, submissions are subject to editorial screening and identity verification.

As illustrated in Appendix 3, access barriers across scientific platforms form a continuum, ranging from explicit requirements (e.g., endorsement or credential checks) to increasingly implicit and opaque forms of selection, culminating in editorial discretion.

The following example documents a case of explicit access restriction based on platform policy enforcement.


Moderator Feedback

Rejected

The substantive content of the submission appears to be reliant on AI-generated content. This is a violation of PsyArXiv's policies (blog.psyarxiv.com/about-psyarxiv).

PsyArXiv Moderator

Moderator Feedback

Rejected

As this work has been uploaded to another preprint archive (Zenodo), it already has an associated pre-print DOI which makes it unsuitable for our archive. For more information on PsyArXiv policies, please refer to blog.psyarxiv.com/about-psyarxiv.

PsyArXiv Moderator

Figure 7. Screenshot of moderator feedback indicating rejection due to reliance on AI-generated content. This example illustrates how authorship concerns related to AI tools can function as an explicit access barrier. In the present case, a secondary justification was introduced, based on the existence of a preprint hosted on another platform. However, the referenced link was not accessible at the time, raising questions about the verifiability and operational validity of this criterion. This configuration combines a primary explicit rule, AI-related authorship restrictions, with a secondary, non-verifiable condition. As a result, the decision is formally justified, but partially grounded in a criterion that cannot be independently assessed. This case represents a direct entry barrier, where access to dissemination is blocked through explicit policy enforcement, while also highlighting how additional criteria may introduce ambiguity even within formally transparent decisions.

Across these platforms, multiple mechanisms are used to regulate access: explicit social validation through endorsement systems, editorial and identity-based screening, automated or semi-automated filtering processes, and variations in moderation and support responsiveness.

Despite these differences, a common pattern emerges. Access is not uniformly open but conditioned by forms of validation that often depend on prior integration into the scientific system. As a result, independent researchers may face higher uncertainty, additional verification requirements, or prolonged non-response compared to institutionally affiliated users.

In some cases, submissions may also be deprioritized or rejected based on perceived authorship concerns related to large language models. This introduces a distinct form of attribution-based exclusion, where decisions are influenced by assumptions about how the work was produced rather than by its content or procedural status.

This mode differs from process-based exclusion. While process-based exclusion operates through disruption of entry, progression, or completion, attribution-based exclusion operates at the level of perceived legitimacy of authorship, independently of the procedural flow.

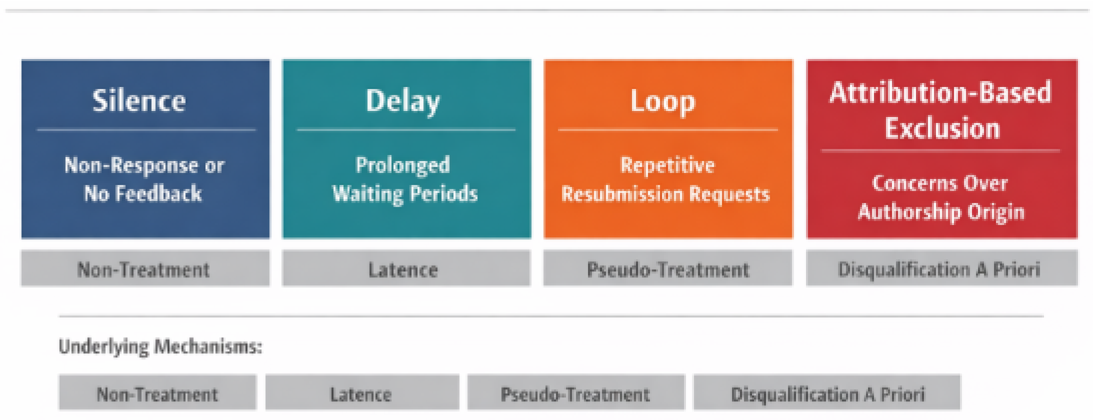
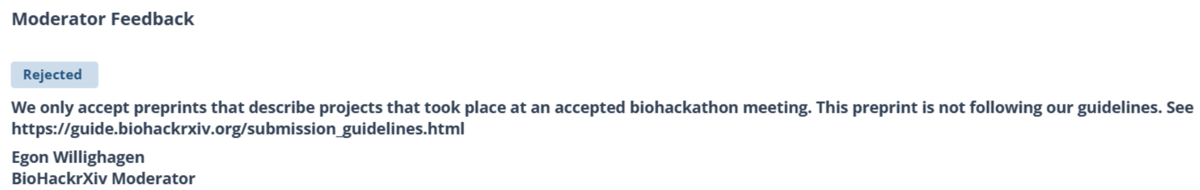


Figure 8. Typology of quiet exclusion mechanisms in scientific systems. Silence, delay, loop, and attribution-based exclusion define distinct process-level barriers, corresponding respectively to non-treatment, latency, pseudo-treatment, and a priori disqualification. Together, these mechanisms constrain participation without explicit rejection, simulating engagement while preventing resolution.

A distinct form of access limitation arises from predefined participation conditions, as illustrated in Figure 9.

+ Eligibility-based exclusion (pre-entry constraint, see figure 9)



Moderator Feedback

Rejected

We only accept preprints that describe projects that took place at an accepted biohackathon meeting. This preprint is not following our guidelines. See https://guide.biohackrxiv.org/submission_guidelines.html

Egon Willighagen
BioHackrXiv Moderator

Figure 9. Access is restricted to submissions meeting predefined participation conditions, independent of content evaluation. This form of restriction is expected and policy-driven, yet contributes to the overall landscape of access limitations.

BOX 1 Internalized Exclusion and Self-Disqualification

In addition to structural barriers, quiet exclusion may operate through internalized mechanisms shaped by asymmetries in research environments. Established researchers typically operate within institutional ecosystems that distribute evaluation across multiple actors, including supervisors, collaborators, students, and peer reviewers, and provide access to material and symbolic resources such as funding, affiliation, and informal feedback channels. These structures externalize a significant portion of evaluative load.

In contrast, independent researchers often operate in isolation, without access to iterative feedback, institutional validation signals, or collaborative calibration. As a result, evaluative processes become internalized and continuous. Quiet exclusion amplifies this condition by withholding explicit decisions and providing only ambiguous or delayed feedback. In the absence of clear external judgment, independent researchers are driven to interpret non-response, stalled processes, or procedural friction as indicators of their own illegitimacy.

Within this context, relatively minor or common imperfections may be cognitively amplified, leading individuals to attribute disproportionate causal weight to small formatting issues, stylistic deviations, or perceived lack of conformity. This produces an asymmetry between perceived fault and actual consequence. While institutional actors benefit from distributed evaluation and buffered progression, independent researchers experience concentrated self-evaluation under uncertainty.

This internalization contributes to the stability of quiet exclusion mechanisms. Because exclusion is interpreted as self-disqualification rather than system-level failure, it generates limited contestation and low external visibility. The absence of explicit rejection not only prevents appeal but also redirects explanatory responsibility toward the individual, reinforcing the persistence of the system without requiring active enforcement.

From Isolated Events to Systemic Pattern

While each case may be interpreted individually as a technical issue, administrative delay, or isolated constraint, their recurrence across independent systems suggests a broader pattern. The similarity of outcomes, despite differences in platform design and governance, indicates that these mechanisms are not incidental but structurally embedded.

This convergence supports the interpretation of quiet exclusion as a systemic phenomenon. Exclusion in contemporary scientific systems is less often achieved through rejection than through sustained delay, which preserves procedural legitimacy while inhibiting effective access. Rather than being limited to specific platforms or policies, it emerges from the interaction between validation procedures, human decision processes, and infrastructural constraints that shape access to scientific participation. The present paper does not claim universal prevalence, but identifies a recurrent process-form across heterogeneous cases.

Box 2. Informal Adaptation and System Circumvention

In response to access barriers encountered on scientific platforms, independent researchers may develop informal adaptation strategies aimed at bypassing validation constraints. These practices typically emerge as reactive adjustments to opaque or unresponsive access mechanisms rather than as primary intentions.

Reports from online discussions suggest that some users attempt to circumvent institutional requirements by providing incomplete, approximate, or unverifiable affiliations. In such cases, affiliation fields may be filled strategically to satisfy platform expectations rather than to accurately reflect institutional belonging. This indicates that validation systems may operate less as measures of research quality and more as proxies for institutional conformity.

These adaptations reveal a structural tension within ostensibly open platforms. While access is formally available, effective entry conditions incentivize alignment with institutional signals, including artificially constructed ones. As a result, systems may favor those able to reproduce expected markers of legitimacy over those who cannot, independently of the intrinsic value of their work.

Importantly, circumvention does not eliminate exclusion but redistributes it. Individuals unwilling or unable to engage in such strategies remain blocked, while others gain access through partial compliance. This produces an uneven participation landscape in which access depends not only on formal criteria but also on the ability to interpret and navigate implicit system expectations.

From a systemic perspective, the emergence of informal adaptation strategies indicates that barriers are both active and perceived as negotiable. This negotiability does not imply openness; rather, it reflects a misalignment between declared accessibility and operational constraints. The need for circumvention can therefore be interpreted as indirect evidence of structural exclusion. When access requires circumvention, openness becomes conditional rather than actual, see figure 10.

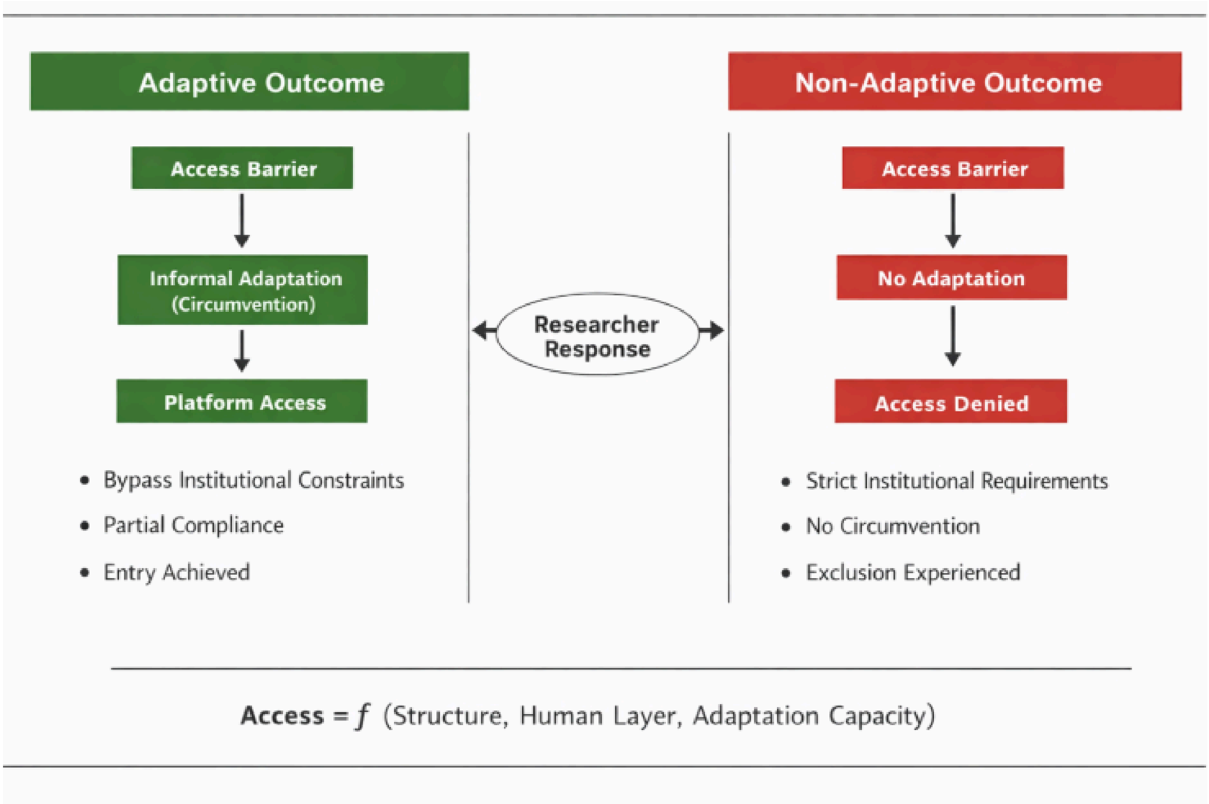


Figure 10. Dual-path model of access: adaptation enables entry, while non-adaptation produces silent exclusion.

Human-Mediated Exclusion in Journal Submission Processes

The dynamics observed in platform access are not limited to account creation or automated validation systems. Comparable patterns emerge within journal submission processes, where human decision-making plays a central role.

Beyond formal criteria such as editorial scope or formatting requirements, independent researchers may encounter exclusion mediated by human factors, including desk rejection, non-response, or implicit credibility filtering. As with platform-based mechanisms, these outcomes are not always accompanied by explicit justification.

In some cases, submissions are neither formally reviewed nor clearly rejected, but receive minimal engagement or standardized responses that do not provide actionable feedback. This produces an indeterminate status, in which the author cannot distinguish between content-based rejection and exclusion linked to perceived legitimacy.

Editorial evaluation often relies on heuristics such as institutional affiliation, prior publication history, or recognizable academic signals. While these heuristics support efficiency, they can also function as implicit filters, particularly at early stages of review, disadvantaging researchers who lack these markers.

This suggests that quiet exclusion is not confined to automated systems but extends into human-mediated evaluation environments. Structural criteria and informal legitimacy assessments combine to form a layered filtering process, where access may be constrained without explicit policy-level exclusion.

As a result, independent researchers may face cumulative barriers across both platforms and journals, with each stage introducing uncertainty, opacity, and a reduced likelihood of integration into formal scientific communication channels.

Human and automated systems differ in form, but converge in producing exclusion through low-visibility filtering mechanisms.

From Outcomes to Processes

Traditional analyses of scientific participation focus on discrete outcomes, most notably acceptance or rejection. However, the cases presented here indicate that access to scientific communication is more accurately described as a multi-stage process, in which participation can be constrained before any final decision is reached.

Three Components of Access

We propose a minimal process-based model in which effective access depends on three sequential components:

Access = Entry × Progression × Completion

Each component represents a necessary condition:

- **Entry**: the ability to access a platform or submit a manuscript
- **Progression**: the ability to move through validation or evaluation stages
- **Completion**: the ability to reach a final decision (acceptance or rejection)

Process Implication

Because the components are multiplicative, a failure at any stage reduces access to zero. As a result, exclusion does not require explicit rejection, it can arise from blocked entry, stalled progression, or absence of completion.

Key Points

Failure at any stage collapses access to zero

Exclusion does not require rejection

Delay acts as a low-visibility filtering mechanism
Systems can be formally open but functionally closed

Entry Constraints

Entry refers to the initial ability to access and participate in a system. Barriers at this stage include institutional email requirements, endorsement systems (e.g., arXiv), asymmetric identity validation, and direct platform restrictions or bans.

These mechanisms may be explicit or implicit, but their common effect is to prevent participation prior to any evaluation of the submitted work. Exclusion at this stage operates by blocking access to the process itself.

Progression Constraints

Progression refers to movement within the system after entry has been achieved. Constraints at this stage include prolonged delays, non-response, repetitive response loops without advancement, and deprioritization based on weak or absent legitimacy signals.

In this configuration, the process remains formally active but functionally inactive. Interaction persists, yet fails to produce forward movement toward evaluation or resolution.

Completion Constraints

Completion refers to the ability to reach a definitive outcome within the system. While traditional models assume that processes terminate in acceptance or rejection, the cases presented here show that completion may fail.

Evaluation may remain indefinitely open, no decision may be issued, and feedback may remain insufficient to enable closure. In such configurations, completion is effectively blocked, even though the system continues to appear operational.

Quiet Exclusion as Process Failure

Within this framework, quiet exclusion can be defined as any process in which Entry, Progression, or Completion approaches zero without explicit rejection.

This definition captures multiple mechanisms: denial of access at entry, stagnation during progression, and indefinite evaluation without closure. In each case, participation is prevented not by refusal, but by the failure of the process to reach completion.

Implications of the Multiplicative Model

The multiplicative structure of Entry, Progression, and Completion has several implications.

Local friction produces global exclusion. Even moderate constraints at each stage can combine to reduce overall access to near zero.

Exclusion can occur without decision. A system may remain formally open while being functionally inaccessible.

Different systems converge in outcome. Entry barriers on platforms and progression constraints in journals produce equivalent effects at the level of participation.

Delay functions as a dominant mechanism. Because it operates without triggering rejection, it reduces access while preserving the appearance of procedural legitimacy.

Reframing Scientific Openness

This model suggests that openness cannot be evaluated solely by who is allowed to submit or by acceptance rates.

Instead, openness must be assessed across the full process: the ability to enter, to progress, and to reach a decision.

A system that is open at entry but fails at progression or completion remains functionally exclusionary.

In this model, access is not determined by acceptance, but by the ability to complete the process.

Among the identified mechanisms, delay plays a central role. By maintaining the appearance of ongoing evaluation while preventing timely completion, delay enables exclusion without conflict or visibility. It reduces the need for explicit rejection while preserving procedural legitimacy. As such, delay constitutes a structurally stable and scalable form of exclusion across both platforms and journal systems.

Importantly, these mechanisms do not necessarily result from deliberate intent. They may emerge from routine system dynamics, including workload distribution, prioritization heuristics, and evolving concerns about authorship and legitimacy. However, the absence of intent does not reduce their effects. From the participant’s perspective, the outcome remains consistent: limited access, prolonged uncertainty, and eventual disengagement.

Recognizing these processes has direct implications for how scientific openness is evaluated. Openness cannot be inferred solely from the absence of rejection or the existence of submission pathways. It must be assessed in terms of whether participants can enter, progress, and reach completion within a reasonable timeframe.

Without this, systems may appear inclusive while remaining functionally exclusionary. A system can be open in form and closed in outcome.

Discussion

This study examined access barriers encountered by independent researchers across scientific platforms and publication processes, with particular attention to forms of exclusion that occur without explicit rejection. The findings support the existence of a mechanism referred to as quiet exclusion, in which access is constrained through non-response, delayed processing, or implicit validation requirements rather than formal denial. Across cases, exclusion may arise at entry, during validation, or after active participation, indicating that barriers are distributed across the full lifecycle of scientific interaction.

A key implication is that exclusion in contemporary scientific systems does not rely solely on explicit gatekeeping. Instead, it emerges from the interaction between structural requirements and human-mediated processes. Institutional affiliation, email domain, and recognizable academic signals function as heuristic proxies for legitimacy, influencing whether submissions are processed, prioritized, or ignored. Access is therefore shaped not only by content or quality, but also by initial signals of conformity to institutional norms.

Quiet exclusion differs from traditional rejection in both form and consequence. Explicit rejection provides a defined outcome, along with feedback, justification, and potential avenues for revision or appeal. In contrast, quiet exclusion produces indeterminate states: submissions are neither accepted nor rejected, but remain suspended in prolonged uncertainty. While both mechanisms may result in access denial, they differ in visibility, traceability, and accountability.

Online discussions suggest that independent researchers frequently encounter validation ambiguity, dependence on institutional email, and prolonged non-response. In response, some users report adopting informal strategies, such as declaring fictitious affiliations, indicating that access barriers are not only present but actively navigated.

The recurrence of similar patterns across platforms, preprint systems, and journal workflows suggests that this form of exclusion is not incidental. Rather, it may emerge from the structure of scientific infrastructures themselves, which rely on distributed validation, limited support capacity, and implicit norms of legitimacy. Within such systems, non-response functions as a low-cost filtering mechanism, allowing participation to be restricted without requiring explicit decisions.

The presence of informal adaptation strategies introduces an additional asymmetry. Individuals able or willing to reproduce expected signals of legitimacy may gain access, while others remain excluded. As a result, participation becomes partially dependent on the ability to interpret and align with implicit system expectations, rather than solely on the content or quality of the work.

These findings have broader implications for the narrative of open science. While access to scientific content has expanded significantly, access to authorship and participation remains uneven. Quiet exclusion challenges the assumption that openness at the level of access to knowledge implies openness at the level of contribution.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The analysis relies in part on case-based observations and qualitative evidence, which may not capture the full variability of platform behaviors. Online reports are subject to selection bias and may overrepresent more salient or negative experiences. In addition, platform-specific policies and workflows vary, limiting the direct generalization of individual cases across systems.

Future research could extend this work through systematic measurement of response times, validation outcomes, and access probabilities across different researcher profiles, including variations in affiliation, email domain, and publication history. Controlled experimental designs, such as standardized submission attempts with manipulated identity signals, could help quantify the influence of initial legitimacy cues on access. Further investigation into platform governance, moderation practices, and support responsiveness would also contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of these mechanisms.

In conclusion, quiet exclusion describes a form of access limitation that operates without explicit rejection yet produces comparable outcomes. Its identification highlights the need to evaluate scientific systems not only in terms of formal openness, but in terms of effective participation across entry, progression, and completion. Recognizing and documenting these processes is essential for advancing transparency, accountability, and equitable access to scientific contribution

Key points

Open systems can produce exclusion without decisions
Legitimacy signals act as hidden filters
Non-response functions as scalable exclusion
Independent researchers face cumulative process friction

References

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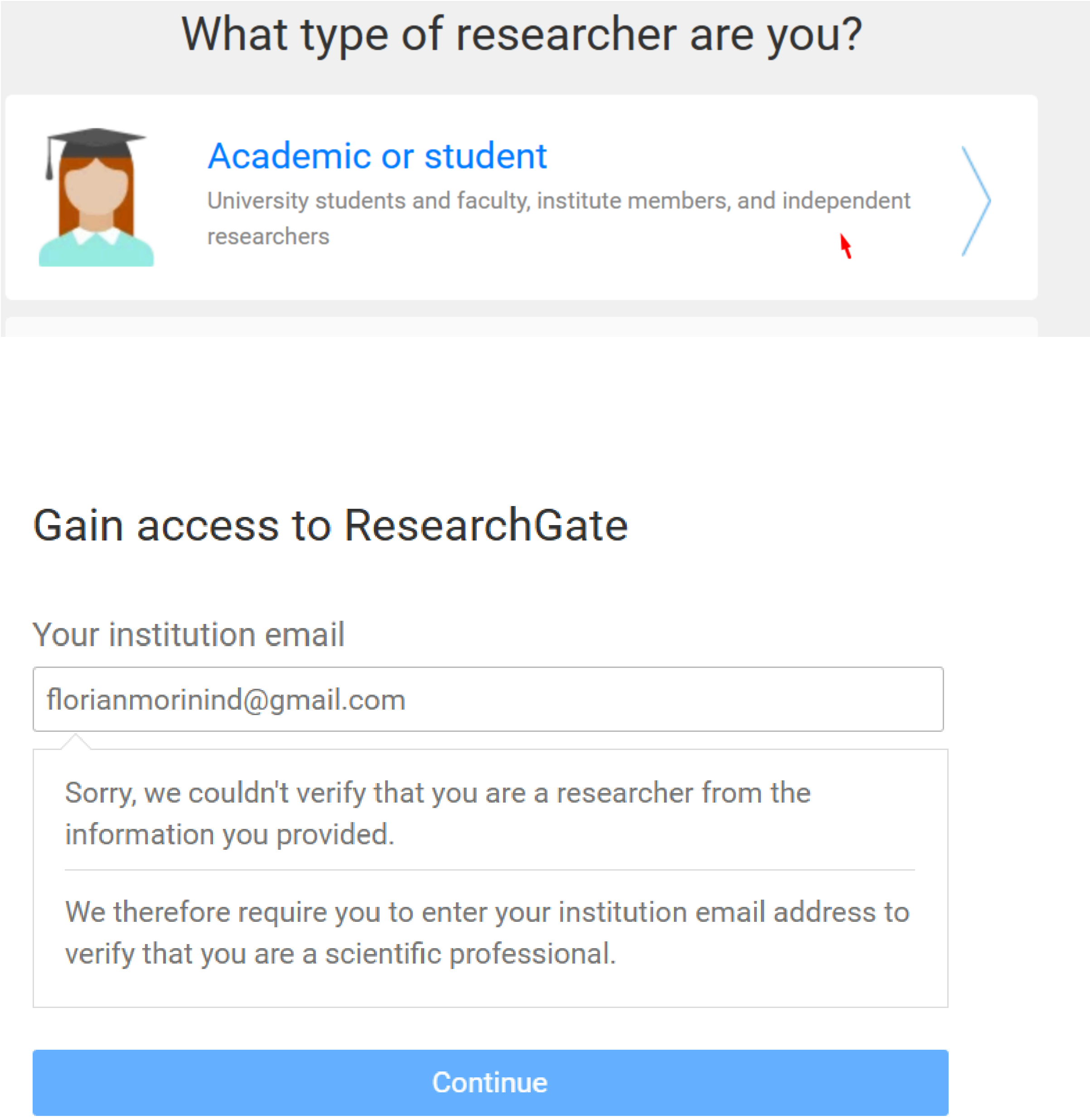
Appendix 1



Appendix Figure 1 Institutional Email Verification Barrier (ResearchGate)

Screenshot showing access restriction on ResearchGate. The platform rejects a personal email address and requires an institutional affiliation to verify researcher status, preventing account validation despite provided information.

Appendix 2

Independent Research Documentation
Case Record Archive

Zenodo Account Restriction – Documented Case

Author: Florian Morin
Version: 1.0
Date: March 2026

Summary

This document provides a structured record of a Zenodo account restriction, including a timeline of events, a description of uploaded content, and a clarification request. The objective is to document the sequence of interactions and identify potential factors contributing to the restriction.

Context

The uploads are part of an independent research corpus focused on joy mechanisms and evaluative load (Z framework). The materials consist of structured documents intended for open dissemination.

Timeline

- **[December 2025]** – Initial uploads
- **[January]** – Additional uploads (multiple entries and versions)
- **[February, 20]** – Account restriction and content removal
- **[February, 20]** – Support contacted
- **+4 weeks** – No response received

Nature of Content

The uploaded materials consist of structured documents including titles, abstracts, and references. Each entry is associated with distinct identifiers (titles, dates, DOIs).

Multiple documents and versions were uploaded within a relatively short timeframe.

Observed Outcome

The account was restricted and uploaded records were removed. The removal notice indicated:

- Reason: Spam
- Action: Automatic system removal
- Additional outcome: User account blocked
- Metadata retained for archival purposes

No detailed justification or actionable feedback was provided.

Potential Misclassification

The frequency and structure of uploads, including multiple documents and versions submitted within a limited timeframe, may resemble automated or bulk submission patterns.

This similarity may have contributed to automated classification as spam.

Request for Clarification

A request for clarification and review was submitted to Zenodo support.

At the time of writing, no response has been received after four weeks.

Clarification is requested regarding:

- The specific criteria used for classification
- Whether the restriction can be reviewed
- The possibility of restoring access to the removed records

List of Uploads

Titre	Date	Doi
Transient Suppression of ACC Monitoring Enables High-Salience Positive Affect	24/12/2025	Not available
Affective Collapse Under Causal Closure	January 2026	10.5281/zenodo.18537408
Ease: Evaluation kills entry, not the state: a threshold model of ease	January 2026	10.5281/zenodo.18224573
Regime-Preserving Methods for Studying Children's Engagement.pdf	January 2026	DOI10.5281/zenodo.18235196
Ease Open-State Questionnaire	February 2026	

(EOSQ,Draft): What the Open State Feels Like		10.5281/zenodo. 18654831
Lock-in under suspended optimization	January 2026	Not available
Positive Affect Contingent On Suspended Optimization	January 2026	Not available
Positive Affect as Suspension of Optimization	January 2026	Not available

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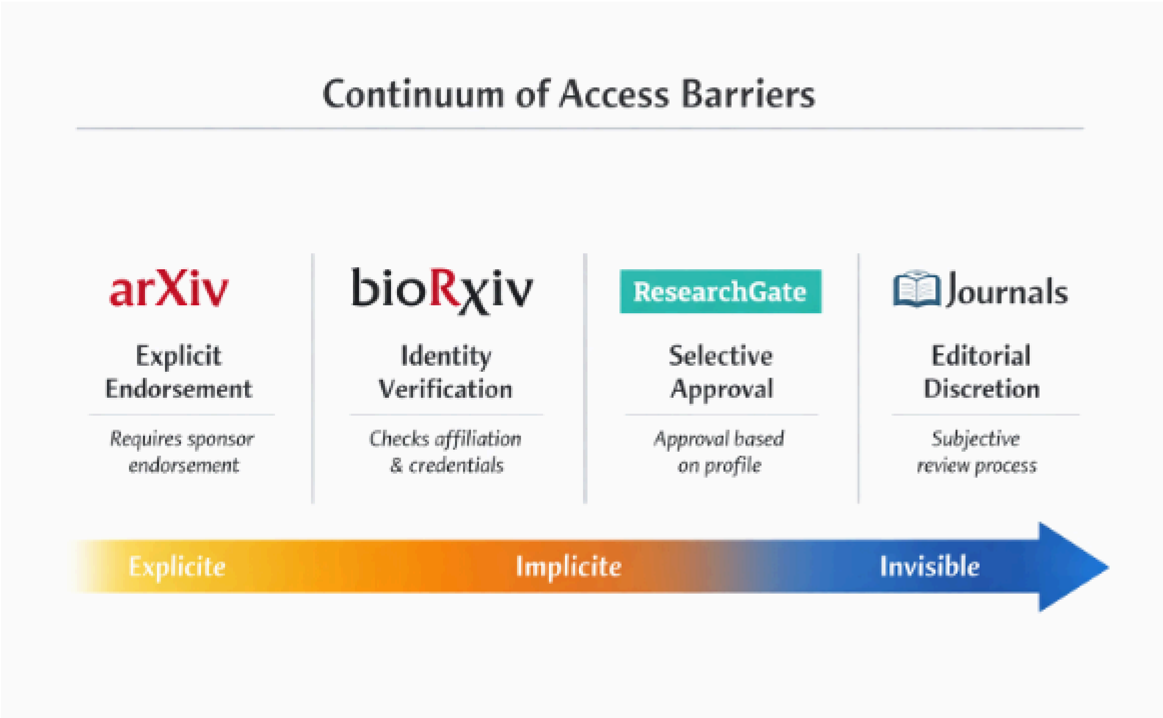
> ***Some entries could not be fully reconstructed due to limited access following account restriction.***

A general description of the research corpus is available online (FAQ format), providing additional context on the nature and structure of the uploaded materials: https://florianmorin.com/assets/pdf/Ease-Framework.pdf

Notes

This document is intended as a factual record of events and does not assume intent or error. It aims to support analysis of access processes and potential classification mechanisms in open science platforms.

Appendix 3



Appendix Figure 2 Continuum of access barriers across scientific platforms. Continuum of access barriers across scientific platforms, from explicit requirements (e.g., endorsement or credential checks) to increasingly implicit and opaque forms of selection, culminating in editorial discretion.